


ANI

PUNJAB

# A FATAL RIDE

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

**A VIOLENT END**
Moosewala in a signature pose; (inset) the bullet-riddled SUV in which he was shot

It was a dull Sunday evening in the village of Jawaharke in Punjab's Mansa district when residents were jolted out of their reverie by the sound of continuous gunfire. Minutes later, the villagers rushed out to find that the victim was local boy and international rapper/ singer Shubhdeep Singh Sidhu a.k.a. Sidhu Moosewala, whose hit singles had names like 'So High' and 'Warning Shots'. The singer was waylaid and shot in his SUV and died while being taken to the hospital.

The last such murder of entertainers in Punjab was in 1988, when prominent singer duo Amar Singh Chamkila and his wife Amarjot Kaur were gunned down. That happened when the violent Khalistan movement was at its peak; today, they blame it on the free run of gangsters. Canada-based Goldy Brar, an erstwhile member of the Lawrence Bishnoi gang, allegedly claimed responsibility for Moosewala's murder in a Facebook post. More worrying was the weapon used in the crime—an AN-94 assault rifle. The Russian-make weapon is an uncommon choice—it fires in two-bullet bursts and can pepper a target with up to 1,800 rounds per minute. It also requires special skillsets to use. The Indian security forces do not use it; it is not a common choice even in Russia. Punjab Police say it's the first time such a weapon has been used in the state. "It's